

The important thing is to reframe how you see budgeting. You might be used to seeing it as a way to punish or chastise yourself, or as something that's too time-consuming or complicated, or just not 'for you'. But it doesn't have to be any of those things, and it really is for everyone, I promise. Incorporating it into your lifestyle as one of the most important ways that you look after yourself is something that will incrementally improve and maintain your financial wellbeing through the ups and downs of life, and fluctuations in your income and outgoings. Like any other relationship, it's important that you feel *safe* in your relationship with money, and having a steady, well-maintained budget will afford you that feeling of control and security. Your budget isn't something that exists to restrict you, it should simply be an Excel manifestation of your control over your finances.

Exercise: Looking at where your budget has gone wrong

Because it's likely that you've had a least one stab at budgeting in the past, the first thing I'd like you to do is to think about the methods that you've used before, and where you think you went wrong, or where they failed to meet your needs. Don't be tempted to focus on the failure aspect – we've all started things that we didn't finish, after all – rather, think about why you weren't able to live with that budget. Was it too vague? Too restrictive? Too